

I want. Having a big bank account just means that I'm not beholden to others. I can follow my passions and dreams wherever they take me. If my job is not satisfying to me, I'm no longer tied to that paycheck; I can just get up and walk away. I can do whatever makes me happy and avoid most of what makes me sad, without regrets or worries.

It's a lot of hard work to climb that mountain, but the air up there is the sweetest thing there is.

Want to know more?

You can check out the five business cards I drew up online (TheSimpleDollar.com). If you liked the information here, take the time to dig into TheSimpleDollar.com, or my book, *365 Ways to Live Cheap!* Also check out some of the other excellent personal finance blogs out there—they do a far better job of humanizing and explaining money and personal development than many of the “big” corporate sites.

Most importantly, remember that you *can* do this. Years ago, I was almost bankrupt and in deep despair because I didn't believe this stuff, either. It took a lot of learning and a lot of honest soul-searching, but I began to realize what was really important and I turned the ship around. Trust me: You can do it, too. — **Trent Hamm**

10 Ways to Simplify Your Budget

I'm always looking for ways to simplify my finances (I'm weird like that, I know), and recently I've been scrutinizing my already-simple budget to make it even simpler. I thought it would be helpful to share some of the ways to make your budget as simple as possible.

The goal is to reduce headaches, eliminate the need for complicated tracking schemes, and reduce the time you spend on your budget and finances to about 15–20 minutes per week. I can't claim these ideas are original, or that I haven't discussed them in various places before, but in my experience, they work. They're simple and powerful.

Let's first look at setting up a budget. If you haven't done it yet, it's probably because budgets seem intimidating to you, or they are too much hassle to set up and maintain. Those are both valid points—which is why you should follow this simplified plan if these things apply to you. Now, there's plenty of fancy software out there for setting up budgets, but I don't think